3.3 BASIC FOUR FOOD GROUPS AND ITS SIGNIFICANCE

Food groups have been classified according to various methods from time to time. ICMR (2011) has classified the different foods items into four food groups as listed in Table 1. They are

1. Cereal, millets and pulses
2. Milk, and animal products
3. Fruits and vegetables
4. Fats, oils and nuts

Significance of the Four-Food Group System

The four food group system can be used for the following purposes:

i. Planning wholesome balanced menus to achieve nutritional adequacy.
ii. Assessing nutritional status – a brief diet history of an individual can disclose inadequacies of food and nutrients from any of the four groups.

Based on the assessment, nutrition education can be imparted to the individual.

The quantity of the meals can be improved or is said to be optimum when the diets are complete. Every meal should have foods providing energy, protein, vitamins, minerals, fibre and adequate amount of water.

Table 1 Basic Four Food Groups

	Food Groups	Main Nutrient
1	Cereal Millets and Pulses: Rice, wheat, ragi, bajra, maize, rice flakes	Energy, protein, invisible fats, vit B1, B2, folic acid, iron, fibre
	Pulses and legumes : bengal gram, black gram, green gram, red gram, rajmah	Energy, proteins, invisible fats, vit B1, B2, folic acid, calcium, iron fibre
2	Milk and Animal products: milk, curd, skimmed milk, cheese, chicken, liver, fish, egg, meat	Protein, fat, vit B2, calcium
3	Fruits and Vegetables : Mango, guava, tomato, papaya, orange, etc Green leafy vegetables: amaranth, spinach, coriander leaves, fenugreek leaves, drumstick leaves Other vegetables: carrot, brinjal, beans, Onions, etc	 Carotenoids, vitamin C, vit B2, iron, folic acid, fibre Carotenoids, vitamin B2,folic acid, fibre Carotenoids, folic acid, calcium
4	Oils, Fats and nuts Fats, butter, ghee, hydrogenated fat, cooking oil like groundnut, mustard, sunflower sugar, jaggery, sugar,Cane Almonds, walnuts, and gingelly seeds	Energy, fat, essential fatty acid Energy Protein, Omega 3 fatty acid

Chapter3_046_069.indd 4 18-01-2019 12:08:54